

Visions in the jungle

Peruvian artist Pablo Amaringo trained as a *curandero* (medicine man) in the Amazon basin. *Curanderos* use local plant remedies to treat physical, mental, and psychological ailments, sometimes aided by Catholic prayers and rituals originally brought to Latin America by Spanish colonists. Amaringo was an *ayahuasquero*—a specialist *curandero* who works with a psychoactive plant brew called *ayahuasca*, used as a traditional spiritual medicine. In 1977, he retired to become a painter, and he later founded a school of art dedicated to recording and preserving the indigenous way of life and the rainforest flora and fauna.

Amaringo's intricate paintings depict the visions he saw under the influence of *ayahuasca*. As he painted, he sang *ícaros*—magical chants that induce a trance during an *ayahuasca* ceremony. He believed that he sent the magic of the *ícaros* into his paintings, ready to transmit their power and knowledge to the receptive beholder. The picture on the left represents the wonder of the plant kingdom, creating the food and oxygen that humans need to survive. The anacondas in the water warn of the dangers of destroying rivers, lakes, and forests. At the top of the painting the huge eyes of the Mother of the Forest look down, while on the left *bufeos* (river dolphins) are lined up like plants to indicate how closely all life forms interlink.

“A *curandero* has in his mind and heart the attitude of conserving nature ...”

PABLO AMARINGO, SACRED HOOP MAGAZINE, 2006

